says. "I was part of four individual events, where I made two finals, and four relays, so I had 10 races where I put in my best effort. Of course, it would have been great to be a lot quicker."

That mark of 54.48 seconds at the Asian Games would be his fastest time on the 100-metre backstroke during the Olympic qualification period. Consistent performances ensured that he eventually made it to the Games, this time around through the Universality quota. Tokyo, though, was a lot different, where he made the 'A' standard qualification timing during an out-of-competition trial to ensure a direct entry. "It doesn't really matter how I got there. I'm in the best shape that I've ever been and it's all a matter of clicking on that day and executing things well," he adds. "The Olympics is just another meet where the goal is to swim the best race I can."

Srihari comes from a family of cricketers and started playing multiple sports while growing up in Bengaluru. Swimming became a priority once he turned 16 and he has represented India at the World Championships besides other multi-sport events. He capped off the National Games last year with 10 medals (eight gold, a silver and a bronze) across backstroke and freestyle events, earning the 'Best Male Athlete' title.

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However, he will not be the lone Indian representative in the pool in Paris. Dhinidhi Desinghu, all of 14, also made the cut through the Universality quota in the 200-metre freestyle event. A two-member contingent in an Olympic discipline that doles out as many as 35 medals demonstrates how far behind India is in this sport dominated by the US, Australia, China, Canada, Great Britain and France. "Swimming is growing on the whole. But we cannot expect things to change overnight," says Srihari. Over the past few weeks, he has been fine-tuning his skills under coach Nihar Ameen in Bengaluru to save those precious milliseconds that he's now all too familiar with. The target is to get a personal best, which he believes will be good enough to get him a spot in the semis. That alone will be a massive first for Indian swimming. ■

–Shail Desai